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How Canada Legalized Weed — and What the U.S. Can Learn

A conversation with Brad Poulos on regulation, retail, taxes, and normalization.

Host Mr Gudwudz sits down with Brad Poulos — former tech founder, entrepreneurship professor at Toronto Metropolitan University, and architect of Canada's first university cannabis-business program.

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Brad: bradpoulos.com · The show: unscriptedcannabis.com

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A NOTE FROM THE SHOW

Canada has a five-year head start on cannabis legalization, and Brad Poulos has spent that whole time studying it from the inside. This companion distills the conversation into the seven ideas most worth stealing — whether you're building in cannabis, watching U.S. reform, or just curious why the rules feel upside down.

CHAPTER 01

One rulebook to grow it, thirteen to sell it

Canada made one structural choice that shaped everything after it: production is regulated only at the federal level, while distribution is left to the provinces. Growing cannabis and making edibles, drinks, and hashish all follow a single national rulebook — which, Brad notes, actually makes life simpler for producers.

Selling it is another story. Ten provinces and three territories each set their own retail rules, producing everything from fully private markets to government-owned monopolies. That patchwork, not the plant, is where most of the friction lives.

CHAPTER 02

Ontario's oversupply — more stores than beer

Ontario went fully private, and the result is a retail glut. There are now roughly 1,600 cannabis stores in the province — next door, government-run Quebec has around 200 for more than half the population.

“We have more places you can buy cannabis than you can buy beer in Ontario. And that has to shake itself out, because it’s not sustainable.”

— Brad Poulos

Brad is a free-market capitalist and still calls Ontario oversupplied. A 10% cap on how much a licensed producer can own of a retailer keeps the two industries separate, but nothing stops the storefront count from outrunning demand.

CHAPTER 03

The excise tax that backfired

The federal excise tax is a flat \$1 per gram. It was set when cannabis averaged about \$10 a gram — a reasonable-looking 10%. Then massive overbuilding crushed wholesale prices to \$3–\$4 a gram.

At that price, a dollar is a quarter to a third of the cost — and it lands hardest on the legal producers who also carry testing and packaging costs. The tax meant to kill the illicit market ends up handing it a price advantage.

CHAPTER 04

Childproofing a substance with no lethal dose

Here is Brad's cleanest contradiction. Cannabis has no LD50 — no known lethal dose — and flower isn't even psychoactive until it's heated. Yet every gram must ship in childproof packaging.

“There's no lethal dose of cannabis — yet we put it in a childproof package. Alcohol, which absolutely has a lethal dose, does not. So explain that one to me.”

— Brad Poulos

Alcohol, which absolutely has a lethal dose, does not. Brad would keep childproofing for gummies, which look like candy, but calls childproofed flower simply senseless.

CHAPTER 05

Regulate it like alcohol, not tobacco

Canada modeled its cannabis advertising rules on tobacco. Brad's argument is that the real analog is alcohol — the use case, the social setting, and the risk profile all line up far closer to a drink than a cigarette.

Pick the wrong analog and you inherit the wrong rulebook. The host adds his own version of the problem: promoting a smoking accessory gets him banned the moment his copy mentions cannabis at all.

CHAPTER 06

A gateway off of opioids

The oldest knock on cannabis is that it's a gateway drug. Brad doesn't dodge it — he inverts it. Cannabis, he argues, is a gateway off of opioids, not onto harder drugs.

“It's absolutely a gateway drug. It's a gateway off of opioids. That's what it's a gateway to.”

— Brad Poulos

He ties the lingering stigma to time (alcohol has been legal a century), U.S. federal prohibition, and Canada putting a former police chief in charge of legalization — the minister who insisted they were trying to “legalize cannabis, not normalize it.”

CHAPTER 07

Why normalization won't reverse

Brad doesn't see Canada going backward. Somewhere between a quarter and a third of adults use cannabis, and even 15–20% of people over 65 still do. Roll that back and you anger a huge, motivated bloc while pleasing a group that mostly doesn't care.

That math, he says, makes reversal “political suicide.” Normalization is slow — but it moves in one direction, and medical legitimacy keeps paving the way.

IDEAS WORTH STEALING

Seven takeaways

- 01** Separate what you regulate: production and distribution are different problems.
- 02** Free markets oversupply — plan for the shakeout.
- 03** A flat tax on a falling price becomes a subsidy for your competitor.
- 04** Match the rule to the risk, not to the nearest political analog.
- 05** “Gateway” cuts both ways — cannabis can be a gateway OFF opioids.
- 06** Normalization follows usage; usage follows medical legitimacy.
- 07** Policy design, not the plant, decides whether legalization works.

CONNECT

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